

No Room For Them - Composer's Notes

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This piece was composed in the autumn of 2025. It marks my first attempt at a symphonic arrangement, blending elements of classical music and New Age. The entire work is realized with a fully digital symphonic setup, requiring only three synthesizer keyboards and a small ensemble of four to five performers. By the pigeonhole principle, there will inevitably be at least one keyboard with more than two players standing in front of it.

Fusion of Classical and New Age Styles

The advantage of adopting a classical foundation is that it allows for works with real depth and musicality — the creative ceiling is far higher than that of any popular music genre, a fact widely acknowledged in the industry. The New Age style, which emerged around 1980, brings two key benefits when fused into the mix:

1. **A richer sonic backdrop:** New Age makes heavy use of digital pads to paint the “background layer.” Not only does this blend seamlessly with traditional orchestral textures, but it also reduces the need for a 50-player string section.
2. **Structural flexibility:** Incorporating New Age elements does not compromise the ability to craft refined formal structures. A prime example is Yanni, whose signature work *Santorini* builds an entire 5-6 minute piece from a fixed motif based on a third interval — the same underlying logic Beethoven used in his *Hammerklavier Sonata* (Op. 106).

Although the style sits somewhere between classical and New Age, the instrumentation follows the “three-keyboard setup” that became popular after 2010 — a configuration originating in 21st-century pop music. The division of labor looks like this:

- **Primary melodic instruments:** handled by the first keyboard
- **Color instruments (2–3 types):** handled by the second keyboard
- **Textural layers (e.g., string pads):** handled by the third keyboard

Additionally, small percussion instruments should have a sense of spatial presence, which can be achieved by positioning players strategically on stage. Larger percussion can be performed live, triggered via synthesizer drum pads, or even pre-sampled and assigned to less frequently used keys — for instance, the highest or lowest octave of a keyboard.

Instrumentation Setup

According to the commissioning party — Austin Chinese Church — two keyboards were already available:

- **Korg Kronos** (owned by the church)
- **Korg Kross** (personally owned by the band leader)

The church band also features excellent lead vocalists (both female and male), as well as a choir with many new members whose skills are still developing.

Among the two keyboards, the **Korg Kronos** stands out with what is arguably the best piano sound in the industry as of 2025 — so realistic that it can almost pass for a real concert grand. It’s the obvious choice for the **primary melodic instrument**. The **Korg Kross**, being an entry-level model, is better suited for **textural layers**, so the **string pad** part is assigned to it.

That left us missing one crucial piece: the **color instruments**. After consulting two composer friends and long-time collaborators — **Tao LIU** and **Yifan SHAN** — and reviewing professional evaluations, we all agreed that the **Yamaha MODX series** is the best choice. Its harp, clarinet, and trumpet patches are considered top of the industry (as of 2025), and these three are exactly what this piece requires as its primary color instruments. Conveniently, a used **Yamaha MODX8+** was available at the local Guitar Center here in Austin — so I quickly snapped it up.

With that, the essential “big three” are complete. The roles are assigned as follows:

Instrument Category	Assigned To	Reason
Primary melodic instrument (piano) + Drum triggers	Korg Kronos	Industry-leading piano sound. Touchscreen “drum pads” allow flexible percussion assignment.
Color instruments (clarinet + trumpet + harp)	Yamaha MODX8+	Industry-leading orchestral sounds. Three instruments fit perfectly, with two performers sharing the front.
Textural instruments (e.g., string pad)	Korg Kross	Doesn’t need to be perfect. Same brand as the main keyboard, ensuring seamless integration.

Composition

Both the first and second themes appear in two contrasting forms — a **minor-mode version** and a **major-mode version**.

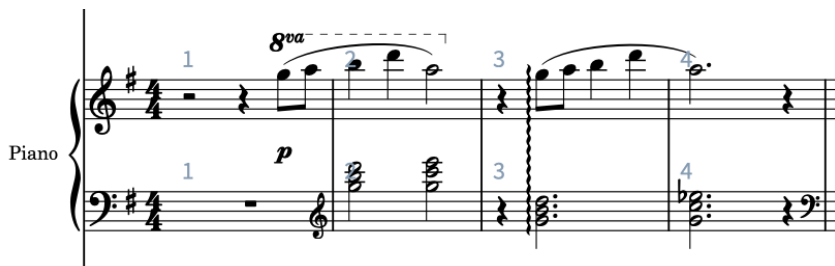
First Theme

The **minor version** of the first theme is as follows:



It first appears in **Section A** (the *semi-exposition*), where it is sung alternately by **two solo vocalists**. There is another instance of the **minor-mode version**, which we will discuss later.

The **major-mode version** of the first theme appears twice — both times in the **introduction**:



It is quite clear that the **first phrase** has a **4/4 feel**, while the **second phrase** (presented an octave lower) shifts into a **3/4 feel**. This subtly foreshadows the transition into **triple meter** in Section B and adds a touch of playfulness to the music. However, it also makes the clarinet “**response phrase**” that follows more challenging — the performer will likely need several attempts to confidently pinpoint the correct beat for the entrance.

In the semi-recapitulation (*Section C*):



It is quite clear that the note on “山” in measure **94** has been **stretched from its original one beat to three beats** — a significant contrast to how it was presented in the **semi-exposition (Section A)** in minor mode. To ensure the audience isn’t caught off guard

by this change, I first **extended the note to two beats in Section B** as a kind of subtle “preview.”



To further reinforce the idea, the **female vocalist** repeats the phrase once more — this time **in the relative major key**.

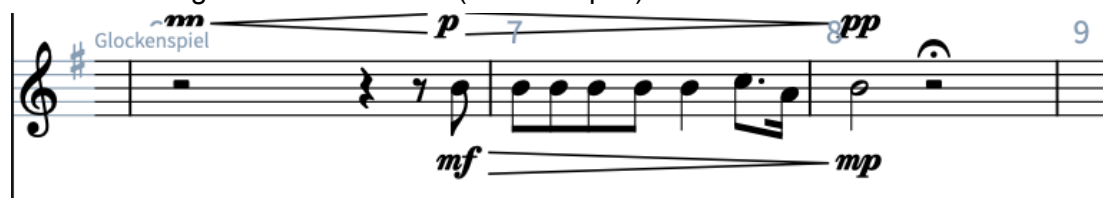


Since the **high note of the first theme** had already been **extended from one beat to two beats in Section B**, stretching it further to **three beats in Section C** no longer feels unexpected. As a result, musicians and singers with a good sense of musical structure — including several I’ve spoken with — can still immediately recognize it as the **first theme**, which is precisely what I intended.

Second Theme

The **minor-mode version of the second theme** is thoroughly **foreshadowed** both in the **introduction** and in **Section A (the semi-exposition)**.

Foreshadowing in the Introduction (Glockenspiel):



Foreshadowing in Section A (Piano):



Therefore, when the **second theme** reappears in **major mode** and is performed by the **choir in Section C (the semi-recapitulation)**, experienced listeners should feel a **joyful sense of both familiarity and freshness**:

Soprano 84 *pp* 85 86 87
马 利 亚 约 瑟 莫 要 迷 茫, 待 长 夜 散 去 将 有 大 光。

Mezzo-soprano 84 *pp* 85 86 87
瑟 莫 要 迷 茫, 待 长 夜 散 去 将 有 大 光。

Alto 84 *pp* 85 86 87
茫 待 长 夜 散 去 将 有 大 光。

Tenor 84 *pp* 85 86 87
散 去 将 有 大 光。

Bass 84 *pp* 85 86 87
大 光 大 光。

马 利 亚 约 瑟 莫 要 迷 茫, 待 长 夜 散 去 将 有 大 光。

Combination of the First and Second Themes

In the **first half of Section C (the semi-recapitulation)**, the **second theme** is presented first — sung by the **choir** portraying *angels* — followed by the **first theme** reappearing in **major mode** performed by the **two lead vocalists**. As the section progresses, the two themes become increasingly intertwined and accelerated, eventually modulating from **B major** back to the **home key of E major**, pushing the music toward its climax.

As long as both themes are **fully established** and **prepared contrapuntally** in advance, combining them is not particularly difficult. However, attention must also be paid to the **lyrics**, which should evolve from “**independent statements**” to “**mutual responses**”, and finally to “**a unified message**.” Ideally, the audience should only hear **one line of text at a time**; occasional moments where “two groups sing different lines simultaneously” are acceptable, but this must not become the norm. After all, even three people speaking at once is confusing — let alone singing. Therefore, the real challenge lies in **careful structural planning**, ensuring the **music leaves sufficient space** for the lyrics to breathe.

Additionally, in an “**accelerando toward climax**” context, it becomes easy — and sometimes desirable — to write **non-square phrases** (i.e., phrases of 7 or 9 measures instead of the standard 8). A composer must be acutely aware of such **non-square structures**, understand their **purpose**, and **test their musical logic** repeatedly with *inner hearing*. Otherwise, the result will resemble the kind of *accidental 9-measure phrases* frequently seen in certain low-level worship music — where the composer had no clear intent, the performers keep missing entrances, and experienced listeners feel something is “off.” **Uncontrolled non-square structure** is a compositional mistake, often found among amateur writers.

My friend and fellow composer **Tao LIU** — whose credits include major films such as *Forever Young*, and *The Wandering Earth* (for which his original score — including its fundamental musical architecture and conceptual design — was appropriated and “rewritten” by another party after the producers maliciously withheld payment) — corrected me on this very issue **twice back in 2009**, after which I never made the mistake again.

On Non-Square Structures

Let us take a closer look at **non-square phrase structures**. When **intentional and well-controlled**, they can make a musical sentence more **dynamic and expressive**. But when **unintentional and uncontrolled**, they should be **avoided at all costs**. A good composer must *always* **count the measures** to ensure they are not inadvertently writing a 7- or 9-measure phrase. Non-square structures must be **controlled**, not accidental.

Here are a few positive examples:



Take the **first theme** as an example. Its presentation in the **tenor solo** spans **nine measures**, from **measure 25 to 33**. The first two notes — on the word “*zou*” (走) — function as a **pickup** (*anacrusis*), and therefore are **not counted**. (In fact, I deliberately used a technique I call “**blurring the boundary between pickup and downbeat**” to *sneak in* an extra measure and create a **non-square structure** — for example, at the beginning of Section B.) In addition, the last syllable “*shang*” (上) in measure **34** overlaps with the beginning of the next section and is also **not included** in the count.

Thus, the **first theme** is a **non-square phrase**, but it doesn’t sound awkward. Instead, it conveys a sense of **relaxation** and **rhythmic elasticity**. This is because the irregularity stems from the word “*li*” (里) in measure **30** from the phrase “*returning home*” (*zhong gui gu li* / 终归故里). That single syllable is stretched by **two extra beats**. If you don’t believe me, try shortening “*li*” by two beats and shifting the following word “*ci chu*” (此处) forward by two beats — it will still sound completely natural.

There are **three reasons** why “*li*” can be stretched like this:

1. **Harmonic shift:** The harmony suddenly modulates to **A major (the tonic chord)**, and the listener needs a moment to *process* this surprise.
2. **Poetic phrasing:** In the lyrics, the rhyme scheme typically follows a “**1-2-4**” pattern (first, second, and fourth lines rhyme), so the **third line** — which contains “*li*” — naturally feels like a point for a brief breath.
3. **Melodic contour:** “*Li*” is a **third tone** and happens to be the **lowest point of the melodic contour** at that moment, so a slight pause feels musically appropriate.

This example illustrates a case where I **want the audience to notice the non-square structure** — to *feel* the sense of **stretch and release** it creates.

The next example is the complete opposite: here, I **don't want the audience to notice** the presence of a non-square structure:

The musical score shows measures 48 through 57. The vocal parts (Tenor solo, Soprano, Mezzo soprano, Alto, Tenor, Bass) are mostly silent from measure 48 to 52, with the Tenor solo part starting in measure 53. The piano part (Piano 7) is active throughout, featuring triplets and a 'pp' (pianissimo) marking in measure 53. The lyrics '折愿今夜草中安息' are written under the vocal parts. The score is in G major and 4/4 time, with a metric shift to 3/4 starting at measure 48.

Measures **48–52** form a short “**pre-introduction**” of **five measures** — clearly a **non-square structure**, much like the previous 9-measure example. But here, my **goal is the opposite**: I want the audience **not to notice** the irregularity. To achieve that, I used several techniques:

1. **Metric shift**: Starting at measure **48**, the meter changes from **4/4** to **3/4**. Strictly speaking, this makes measure 48 **ambiguous** — it can easily be perceived as belonging to the **previous phrase** (measure 47 and before).
 - If we group measure 48 with the previous phrase, that phrase itself becomes a **7-measure non-square structure**.
 - In other words, depending on how you divide it, the two phrases can be interpreted as either **6 + 5 measures** or **7 + 4 measures**.
2. **Beat reinterpretation**: The **high G** in measure **49**, if understood as the functional equivalent of the G in measure 48, should be interpreted as the **final beat of the previous bar**, not the **downbeat of the new one**. This deliberate **ambiguity “resets” the listener’s internal sense of meter**, making the irregularity far less noticeable.
3. **Total beat consistency**: In **4/4**, four measures add up to **16 beats**. After the switch to **3/4**, five measures total **15 beats** — nearly the same. This subtle consistency helps the passage **feel smooth and natural** despite the irregular phrase length.

4. The “Rule of Three”: Measures **49–52** follow the so-called “rule of three” — a structural principle not only found in **Propp’s *Morphology of the Folktale*** but also common across *temporal arts* like music. A short phrase is repeated **three times**: the first two are **unchanged**, while the third introduces a **noticeable variation**, leading into new material. In the score, **measures 50–52** feature a **glockenspiel strike on high B on the second beat**, subtly signaling that “*something is about to happen.*”
5. Precisely because I had already created a **five-measure non-square phrase** in measures **48–52**, introducing **another five-measure non-square phrase** immediately afterward in measures **53–57** no longer feels abrupt. On the contrary, since the audience can now perceive the irregularity, it produces a heightened sense of **stretch and release**.

Modulation – Main Direction #1

The **first half of Section B** extends up to **measure 65**. At **measure 65**, there are **two possible overall modulation directions**. The **first direction** is the one adopted in the **current version**:

The image shows a musical score for two vocal parts: Mezzo (Soprano solo) and Tenor solo. The score covers measures 62 through 69. The Mezzo line starts at measure 63 with the lyrics '我们彼此未曾离弃。' and continues with '同赞美：风 雨 彩 虹 是 神 奇 迹。'. The Tenor line starts at measure 62 with the lyrics '每 当 苦 难 黑 暗 来 袭，' and continues with '我 们 同 赞 美：风 雨 彩 虹 奇 迹。'. Dynamic markings include *mp* (mezzo-piano) and *mf* (mezzo-forte). The score is in 4/4 time and features a key signature of one sharp (F#).

This version can be summarized as follows:

- At the **end of measure 61**, the music begins in **B minor**.
- By the **end of measure 63**, it **shifts up a whole tone** to **C# minor**. However, instead of continuing with strict sequential modulation, the harmony changes at “*qi*” (弃) in **measure 65**.
- As a result, by the **end of measure 65**, the harmony does **not** move up by another whole tone. Instead, it **jumps directly to G# minor**.

This creates the classic **III – IV – I** progression: **B – C# – G#**.

After briefly settling in **G# minor**, we again reach a fork in the road at **measure 69**. Here, too, there are **two main modulation directions**. The **first** is the one used in the **current version**, which modulates to the **relative major key — B major**:

67

Cl. in Bb

Glock.

S. solo.

T. solo.

Pno

Hp

mp

mf *mp*

风 雨 彩 虹 是 神 奇 迹。

风 雨 彩 虹 奇 迹。

The **key point** here is **measure 69**. By taking advantage of the many **common chords** shared between **G# minor** and **B major** in the preceding measures, the music **directly** introduces the **dominant chord of B major** at this point.

However, it is also possible to **remain in G# minor** instead. To do this, you would simply **replace the chord in measure 69** with the **dominant of G# minor** and **slightly adjust the vocal lines** for the two soloists:

67 68 69 70 71

A Flat Major...

Adagietto cantabile $\text{♩} = 80$

Cl. in Bb

Glock.

S. solo.

T. solo.

Pno

Hp

S.Pad.

mp *mp* *p* *p*

mf *mp*

风 雨 彩 虹 是 神 奇 迹。

风 雨 彩 虹 奇 迹。

Since **G# minor is enharmonically equivalent to A b minor**, and because the music later modulates to **A b major**, I chose to **notate from measure 69 onward in A b major** for the sake of readability.

This decision does **not diminish the artistic value** of the section in any way. I have also uploaded an MP3 version of this **alternative approach** to GitHub under the filename **Alternative1.mp3**, so you can listen and compare the difference for yourself.

Modulation – Main Direction #2

As mentioned earlier, there are **two possible main modulation directions at measure 65**. The **first** is the one we have already discussed — the version used in the **current arrangement**. But there is also a **second possibility**.

In the first approach, the sequence is **B – C# – G#**, that is, a **III – IV – I** progression. This happens because I introduced a **chord change at the end of C#**, preventing the harmony from following the “expected” stepwise sequence **B – C# – D#**. Instead, it jumps directly to **G#**.

This naturally raises a question: *What if I don't make that chord change and simply let the music move “naturally” from C# to D#?*

The answer is: **of course I can**. And note that **D# is enharmonically equivalent to E b**. This leads us to the **second main direction**, which is structured as follows:

The image displays a musical score for measures 62 through 66. The score is written for four parts: S. solo (Soprano solo), T. solo (Tenor solo), Hp (Harp), and S. Pad. (String Pad). The key signature changes from one sharp (F#) to three flats (Bb, Eb, Ab) at measure 65, indicated by a red box labeled "E Flat Minor". The tempo is marked "Adagietto cantabile" with a quarter note equal to 74 (♩ = 74). The dynamics range from *pp* (pianissimo) to *mf* (mezzo-forte). The lyrics are in Chinese: "我们彼此未曾离弃。同赞美： 苦难黑暗来袭，我们同赞：". The score shows a modulation from C# minor to E-flat minor at measure 65.

67 68 69 70 71 72

Adagietto cantabile ♩ = 80

Cl. in Bb

Glock.

S. solo.

T. solo.

Pno

Hp

S. Pad.

mf mp p

风 雨 彩 虹 是 神 奇 迹。

Similarly, I've uploaded an MP3 of this **alternative version** to GitHub under the filename **Alternative2.mp3**, so you can listen and compare.

Please note that **within the framework of “Main Direction #2”**, there are still **two possible sub-options** at measure 69: you can either **remain in E ♭ minor** or **modulate to its relative major, G ♭ major**.

Modulation – Final Choice

By the end of **Section B**, combining the **two main modulation directions** discussed above yields a total of **four possible outcomes**. Starting from **E minor**, the four options are as follows:

1. **E minor → B minor → (no modulation) → B major**
2. **E minor → B minor → (no modulation) → A ♭ major**
3. **E minor → B minor → E ♭ minor → A ♭ major**
4. **E minor → B minor → E ♭ minor → G ♭ major**

The advantage of “**opening two doors**” in Section B is precisely this: since **Section C** involves a significant **vocal workload** — and since vocal lines are subject to **range limitations** — not all keys are equally suitable. By having **four choices**, relatively evenly distributed across an **octave**, we gain tremendous **flexibility and room for adjustment** for the vocal parts.

Among these, the **first option** (the one used in the current version) is by far the most **logical and musically satisfying**. After entering Section C, **B major** places the vocal range squarely in the “**sweet spot**” — comfortable yet brilliant. The final modulation returns to **E major**, and the climax is crowned by a **high A (A5)** in the soprano line. On one hand, this high A is a **showcase pitch** that professional sopranos love, offering a natural opportunity to display technique; on the other, since the piece itself is in **E minor**, ending in **E major** maintains **tonal unity** and structural coherence.

The **second option** is also worth considering — particularly if no soprano is available and the lead must be sung by a **mezzo-soprano** or **alto**. Because this option is a **minor third lower** than the first, the **highest note** drops from **A5 to F#5**, which is ideal for mezzos and still reachable for most altos.

The **third option** is less practical. If Section C begins in **A ♭ major**, the **first few notes** of the **choral soprano line** must be **G**. Neither **G4** nor **G5** is ideal: **G4** is too low to sound musically satisfying, while **G5** is too high to sing comfortably.

The **fourth option** is again a viable alternative, for similar reasons as the second. Because it is only **one tone lower** than the second, if the lead is sung by an **alto**, this approach works well — the highest note becomes **E5**, a **highlight pitch** for altos: rich, resonant, and warm, yet never harsh.

Roughly speaking, among the female vocalists I know, **Duan WANG** (soprano soloist of the original **Chongwenmen Church Women’s Choir**) is perfectly suited to the **first option**, while **Huimin LI** (alto soloist of the **China National Opera**) is an excellent fit for **options two and four**.

Since there is **one final modulation** to be made in Section C, the resulting key schemes become:

1. **E minor → B minor → (no modulation) → B major → E major** (*return to tonic – recommended*)
2. **E minor → B minor → (no modulation) → A ♭ major → D ♭ major**
3. **E minor → B minor → E ♭ minor → A ♭ major → A ♭ major**
4. **E minor → B minor → E ♭ minor → G ♭ major → B major**

Among these, **only the first option** naturally returns to **E major**. In options **2** and **4**, returning to **E major** would require **special handling in Section C**. Option **4** is particularly challenging (since **G ♭** is a whole tone away from **E**), while option **2** is more manageable and potentially quite effective (because **A ♭** and **E** are separated by a **major third**, making modulation easier and musically attractive). However, this approach sacrifices the “**long dominant pedal**” function that **B major** provides in option 1. Most listeners may not consciously notice the difference — but those with **strong musical training** (or **composer’s OCD tendencies**) will likely pick up on it and feel a subtle sense of regret.

Formal Structure

This work adopts a “**semi-sonata form**” (*semi-sonata-allegro form*) in **E minor**, with the following sections:

- **Introduction (measures 1–8):**
 - Foreshadows the **first theme** (in **G major**)
 - Foreshadows the **second theme** (in **E minor**)
 - Introduces the overarching harmonic concept of **major–minor alternation** (see above)
 - Previews the local harmonic technique of **color-chord insertion** (measures 5–6)
 - Hints at the rhythmic interplay of **4/4 and 3/4 meters** (first 4 measures)
 - Introduces all major instruments, including the **trumpet**
- **Section A – Semi-Exposition:**
 - Presents the **first theme** (in **E minor**)
 - Provides a further preview of the **second theme** (in **E minor**)
 - Establishes a “**false dominant pedal**” (measures 42–46 on **G**) to create tension
- **Section B – Semi-Development:**
 - Develops the **first theme** in various forms (including unconventional **3/4** treatment)
 - Creates a **melancholic atmosphere** (drawing from **New Age** techniques)
 - Concludes with a **half-cadence in the dominant key (B major)**, foreshadowing a return to the tonic (E minor)
- **Section C – Semi-Recapitulation:**
 - Presents the **second theme** in **major**, forming a stark contrast with its earlier minor appearance
 - Presents the **first theme** in **major**, again contrasting its earlier minor version

- Together, these serve as an **extended dominant pedal** (measures 84–108), building **potential energy** for the final return to the tonic
- Concludes in **E major**

The term “**semi-sonata form**” is used because each section fulfills **only half of the traditional sonata functions**, albeit through alternative means.

For instance, **Section A (semi-exposition)** presents the **first theme** and creates tension through a **dominant pedal** (measures 42–46). However, the **second theme** is only **previewed**, not fully presented, and the dominant pedal does not function as a bridge leading to it (since the second theme itself never arrives here). Instead, it serves as a bridge toward the **semi-development** section.

Section B (semi-development) follows the same principle. It remains in **E minor** rather than modulating to a new key, because the overall length of the work is not sufficient to support frequent **tonal center shifts**. Furthermore, the development section does not end with a dominant pedal (i.e., it is not “open”) but rather **resolves into the dominant key (B major)**. This is because the full presentation of the **second theme** (as opposed to its earlier previews) is performed by the **choir**, portraying the **voices of angels** — a moment that requires silence and attentiveness from the audience. In such a context, a “**closure–restart**” structure is far more appropriate than the traditional “**suspense–resolution**” trajectory of sonata form.

Section C (semi-recapitulation) follows a similar logic. In classical sonata form, the development is usually followed by a **large dominant pedal** to build tension before the recapitulation. Here, however, the **first half of Section C** is presented in the **dominant key (B major)**, which itself serves as an **extended dominant pedal**, accumulating enough **energetic momentum** for the final **return to E major** at the conclusion.

Acknowledgments

Finally, I would like to express my heartfelt gratitude to the following teachers, mentors, friends, and collaborators for their invaluable guidance, support, and encouragement throughout the creation of this work (listed roughly in reverse order of when we first met):

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- **Ying HUANG**, my first piano teacher and former accompanist with the National Ballet of China

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- *White Stone Band* and the *Mandarin Hymn Choir*, Austin Chinese Church, Austin, Texas, USA
- **Yifan SHAN**, my friend, hardware engineer, and member of the Shanghai Children's Music Association
- **Tao LIU**, my friend and acclaimed film composer